God's Providence

General Providence

"Providence is the Christian's diary, but not his Bible." - Thomas Boston

A. What God's Providence Is
   1. He upholds, disposes, governs all things (Neh 9.6; He 1.3)
   2. It is according to his infallible foreknowledge and immutable counsel (Eph 1.11)
   3. It extends to everything, from least to greatest (Mt 10.29-31)
   4. It is to the praise of His glorious wisdom, power, justice, goodness, and mercy

B. What God's Providence Is Not
   1. It does *not* subvert second causes (Gen 8.22; Jer 3.1.35; Ex 21.13; Gen 1.19) 1Kgs 22
   2. It does *not* ignore means (Ac 27.24, 31, 44; Is 55.10, 11)
   3. It does *not* involve God authoring or approving sin (1Jn 2.16; Jam 1.13,14)

God's Special Providence

Special Attention

A. God Takes *Special* Care of His Church (Is 43.3f; 1Tim 4.10; Am 9.8f; Rom 8.28)
   - akin to God's *special* love, and his *effectual* call (1Cor 1.9; Rom 8.29)

B. Special Guidance & Comfort (Jn 16.13; Rom 8.26,27; Php 4.6,7)

C. God as our Shepherd, Deliverer, Savior, Strength, Refuge (*"under his wings"*), etc.

Special Promises

A. All Things for Good

Rom 8.28 - "And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose."

   1. God causes all things to cooperate for our spiritual benefit… they work in concert

2. Nothing is exempt; even what is not a *perceived* or *immediate* good, or what was not *intended* for good.
3. "Good" is as God defines it

B. The Good of All Things: Every difficult path is "made straight"

Prov 3.5 - "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. [6]In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

1. God as Maestro. He uses even temptation, sin, suffering and affliction

   Gen 50.20 - *"As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today."*
2. Faith: all things for certain

God's Frowning Providence

His Special Love for His Children

A. The Function of Suffering: God's Fatherly Discipline of his Children

Heb 12.5 - *And have you forgotten the exhortation that addresses you as sons? "My son, do not regard lightly the discipline of the Lord, nor be weary when reproved by him. [6]For the Lord disciplines the one he loves, and chastises every son whom he receives." [7] It is for discipline that you have to endure. God is treating you as sons. For what son is there whom his father does not discipline? [8]If you are left without discipline, in which all have participated, then you are illegitimate children and not sons.*

1. Discipline: God's fatherly discipline of His children (Heb 12.1-13; 2Chr 32.25f; 2Sam 24.1; Mark 14.66f; Jn 21.15f)
2. Testing our faith (1Pet 1.6,7)
3. Union with Christ, being conformed to Christ (2Tim 2.3; cf. 2Cor 1.5-7; Php 3.10)

B. The Fruit of Suffering

1. Sanctification (Heb 12.10)
2. Character (Rom 5.3-5)
3. Fruit of Righteousness (Heb 12.9-11; 2Cor 1.3-7)
4. Our suffering & tried faith result in *"praise & glory"* (1Pet 1.6,7)

C. Faith amidst Suffering (seeing it in the right way)

1. Rejoice (Rom 5.3; Col 1.24; 1Pet 4.13)
2. Perspective: Present :: Future (Rom 8.18; 1Pet 5.9,10)
3. Seeing God's goodness and pure purposes

The Purity of God's Providence (Titus 1.15)

Titus 1.15 - *To the pure, all things are pure, but to the defiled and unbelieving, nothing is pure; but both their minds and their consciences are defiled.*

A. Meaning of "***pure***"
   1. Clean – washed (2Sam 22.26,27; Psa 18.25,26)
   2. Refined - flawless, undivided

B. Through God's providence
   1. Enduring tribulation
   2. Suffering & what it produces
   3. Suffering & how it awakens us
   4. Things directed to/for us… are purifying
   5. e.g., Cross – God used for good

The Seasons of God's Providence (Eccl 3.1-13)

A. There is a time for every season
   1. We are not in control of the seasons
   2. We cannot discern the seasons

B. Problem: Placed in time, curious about eternity

   - Two conclusions
      a. *vv.*12-13: Be happy and enjoy your life.
      b. *vv.*.14-15: We are limited. God is Unlimited.

C. God sees what we do not. God knows (better than we do) what is best.
   1. The seasons we experience, are not random or arbitrary
   2. Perspective of faith: present seasons (of suffering) *seen* in light of eternity
   3. Completeness to our salvation, from beginning to end, *and* everything in between